

final, believes World Cup final scores count higher than those in a domestic trial. After which entering a national team for the Commonwealth Shooting Championships (CSC), the first event that marks the start of an important season, is only logical. She attended all camps, trials and training, and followed the book to even its most annoying rule but was cast aside.

Sodhi, who last year made six out of seven international finals and shot the best average score in the world, can't figure out how the act of abandoning a selection trial along with six others due to malfunctioning targets counts as an act of rebellion that has him ignored.

Olympic silver medallist Rajyavardhan Rathore is in the dock with Sodhi and out of the CSC team for walk-

ing away from the trial even as the NRAI was in denial about Patiala's malfunctioning machines. Young pistol shooter Heena Sidhu, 20, won a World Cup silver medal last season, but is out of the CSC team as well.

The smoke rising from all shooters was out into the open with Bindra's fury. Yet, the decision by the NRAI to leave a slice of India's elite shooters out of their early plans for a year crammed with a world championship, the Commonwealth and Asian Games needs deeper answers: whether the NRAI's selection procedure and its selectors are fair and objective, and whether the NRAI is as fair and judicious a body as it should be.

The questions will have lone wolves howling in laughter. Barring government observer Morad Ali Khan, who attends selection meetings but can't vote, the NRAI selection committee does not feature any world-level experts capable of making decisions across the sport's many arms. The man closest to shooters on the committee is national coach, the long-serving Sunny Thomas who oversees shooters across all disciplines and age groups, and in the words of a shooter, used to be a "buffer" between them and the NRAI.

The issues are not merely about selection. Three legal matters are

now on the NRAI's plate, with a sessions court in Delhi asking the federation's most powerful men to abandon office (see box).

NRAI President Digvijay Singh when contacted by INDIA TODAY said he had not received a copy of the district court judgement and then spoke the language of the great patriarch. "I have been associated with this family for 35 years. As a democrat, I'm prepared to resolve all problems." The nobility of those words do not hide the crux of the problem: the NRAI's functioning itself and its repeated habit of flexing muscle and expecting shooters to genuflect.

Khan, a 2002 Commonwealth Games gold medallist, sighs, "You have to be thick-skinned to be a winner in India." True, but most elite shooters do not belong to the rhino species. The reason they fuss about their training or competition schedule is that they know what and how long it takes to peak, to be utterly precise at important events. The CSC may not be one of those, but for an elite shooter it could be an event to try out a small change in technique or working on a new weapon. At the heart of a competitor's demand is the effort and not, as the NRAI believes, the ego. The NRAI's rules have always been pliant which is why finding themselves off their radar in a major competition year makes shooters anxious and angry.

The latest ruckus around selection trials and major competitions is not a first. In fact, it is almost NRAI's operational policy. Two years ago, trap shooting world champion Manavjit Sandhu finished fourth in a trial conducted for the Doha Asian Games. He was left out of the team before the NRAI changed its mind following, as a shooter described it, "a banging of doors and a tearing of hair". With Sandhu on it, the Indian team won silver at the Asian Games and Sandhu picked up another individual silver medal.

A year later, there was a move to elbow Bindra out of the Olympic proba-



(FROM LEFT) BINDRA, RATHORE, SHIRUR, SODHI

Shot Down by the System

- The NRAI's selection trial has become an exercise in its power over the sport and control over the shooters.
- There is no internationally recognised expert on the selection committee in charge of picking teams for major events.
- Shooters do not have the services of coaches specifically focussed on their disciplines for a lengthy period of time.
- Ranges remain badly equipped and even club venues where trials are held have often been of extremely poor standard.

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